

Chapter Title: Bernard Lonergan: HUMAN INTENTIONALITY AND FAITH

Book Title: The Three Dynamisms of Faith

Book Subtitle: Searching for Meaning, Fulfillment, and Truth

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Published by: Catholic University of America Press. (2017)

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctt1wq8z40.9>

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CHAPTER 5

Bernard Lonergan

HUMAN INTENTIONALITY AND FAITH



Bernard Lonergan (1904–84) was, in my estimation, the premier Roman Catholic theologian of the twentieth century. Basically a Thomist, he nevertheless displayed remarkable creativity in the areas of epistemology, method, and historical consciousness.¹ His contribution to a theology of faith hinges upon two conversions: religious and intellectual. Accordingly, after briefly characterizing a third kind of conversion, the moral one, which is less important here for a theology of faith, this chapter shows the impact of religious and intellectual conversion.² The first two sections discuss the interaction between *religious* conversion and the role of the word and of belief; the third and fourth sections weigh the criticisms addressed to Lonergan by George Lindbeck and David Tracy; the last section has to do with epistemology in light of *intellectual* conversion. In chapter 6

1. For a brief presentation of Lonergan, the context of his thought, with a few of his main themes, see Roy, *Coherent Christianity*, chap. 13, “Bernard Lonergan: A Theologian in Dialogue.” See also Roy, *Engaging the Thought of Bernard Lonergan*, and the interviews given by Lonergan in *Caring about Meaning: Patterns in the Life of Bernard Lonergan*, ed. Pierrot Lambert, Charlotte Tansey, and Cathleen Going (Montreal: Thomas More Institute, 1982).

2. On the three conversions, see Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 237–43.

a section on self-deception will describe a fourth type of conversion, submitted by Robert Doran: the psychic conversion, of which Lonergan approved.

Before getting more specific on conversion, let us observe that it does not amount to a mere development. Following Joseph de Finance, Lonergan draws a distinction between a horizontal and vertical exercise of freedom: "A horizontal exercise is a decision or choice that occurs within an established horizon. A vertical exercise is the set of judgments and decisions by which we move from one horizon to another." Then Lonergan goes beyond de Finance as he subdivides the vertical exercise into two kinds:

Now there may be a sequence of such vertical exercises of freedom, and in each case the new horizon, though notably deeper and broader and richer, none the less is consonant with the old and *a development* out of its potentialities. But it is also possible that the movement into a new horizon involves *an about-face*; it comes out of the old by repudiating characteristic features; it begins a new sequence that can keep revealing ever greater depth and breadth and wealth. Such an about-face and new beginning is what is meant by a conversion.³

So, all four types of conversion—religious, moral, intellectual, and psychic—are an about-face, not a mere development.

Since moral conversion is less directly joined up with faith than religious and intellectual conversion, I will simply consign my characterization of it to one paragraph. Nonetheless, it has a significant function to exercise in encouraging a well-directed hope and in assisting a religious quest.

Moral conversion consists in becoming attuned to values and in preferring the attraction of values to other satisfactions whenever they conflict. It draws from religious experience the motivation required for the overcoming of individual, group, and general bias.⁴

3. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 237–38; italics are mine.

4. On bias, see Lonergan, *Collected Works*, vol. 3, *Insight*, 244–67, and Roy, *Engaging the Thought of Bernard Lonergan*, study 14, section entitled "A Wounded Humanity."

Individual bias is the pursuit of self-interest at the expense of others. Group bias is the pursuit of interests shared by a group or class to the detriment of other groups or classes. General bias affects any society whose common sense confines its horizon to what looks practical in the short term. In order to counter bias and foster progress, people have recourse to religious traditions where they find enlightenment and renewal of their willingness to act rightly.

INTENTIONALITY AND RELIGIOUS CONVERSION

Lonerган distinguishes between four levels of human intentionality: experience, understanding, judgment, and decision. On the first level, we perceive; on the second, we receive insights; on the third, we make judgments; and on the fourth, we decide. Access to truth requires the acceptance of our fourfold desire (labeled “the transcendental notions”): to register all observable data; to understand everything that is intelligible; to reach sound judgments; and to take decisions. Whenever a person knows oneself as involved in one’s intentionality, this self-knowledge enables one to be a responsible agent.

Chapter 4 of his book *Method in Theology* introduces the theme of self-transcendence.⁵ It is the tendency among human beings to go beyond the strict limitations of their habitat and to learn how to live in a world mediated by meanings and values. People transcend themselves inasmuch as they ask questions *for understanding*, which makes them discern intelligible patterns in the data perceptually collected; inasmuch as they ask questions *for reflection*, which makes them determine the truth of their hypotheses; and inasmuch as they ask questions *for deliberation*, which makes them assess values, courses of actions, and religious commitments. Elsewhere, Lonergan calls this development a movement “from below upwards.”⁶

5. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 104–5.

6. Lonergan, “Natural Right and Historical Mindedness,” in *A Third Collection: Papers by Bernard J. F. Lonergan*, ed. Frederick E. Crowe (New York: Paulist Press, 1985), 180.

One ascends a scale, so to speak, constituted by four levels: experience, understanding, reflection, and deliberation. Hence his four transcendental—that is, cross-cultural—precepts: “Be attentive, Be intelligent, Be reasonable, Be responsible,” to which he later adds a fifth, “Be in love.”⁷

He points out, “The transcendental notions, that is, our questions for intelligence, for reflection, and for deliberation, constitute our capacity for self-transcendence. That capacity becomes an actuality when one falls in love. Then one’s being becomes being-in-love.” Among the various kinds of love—all situated on the fourth level of human intentionality—the love of God is supreme. Lonergan is fond of quoting Romans 5:5, “God’s love flooding our hearts through the Holy Spirit given to us.”⁸ Exegetes of St. Paul note the rich ambiguity of the genitive “love of God” (*hē agapē tou Theou*) in this verse of the Letter to the Romans: it means both God’s love for us and our love for God. We could encompass the two senses in the phrase “God’s love in us.”

Such is what Lonergan equivalently calls “religious conversion” or “religious experience.” When a person has received this extraordinary gift, she initiates a movement “from above downwards,” which complements the first movement, “from below upwards.”⁹ This second movement proceeds from a summit—namely, the apex of the soul as imbued with divine love. Then one is attuned to the judgments of value (on the fourth level) and judgments of fact (on the third level) handed on by a religious heritage; one tries to understand the meaning conveyed by these judgments (on the second level); and at the end of this descent, one embodies such meanings in words, symbols, artefacts—that is, in newly created data (on the first level).

Subsequently, in the same chapter of *Method*, Lonergan employs a distinction between the inner and the outer word.¹⁰ Of the latter,

7. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 231 and 268, respectively.

8. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 105.

9. Lonergan, “Natural Right and Historical Mindedness,” 181.

10. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 112–19 and 123.

he writes, "By the word is meant any expression of religious meaning or of religious value."¹¹ Of the former, he writes:

Before it enters the world mediated by meaning, religion is the prior word God speaks to us by flooding our hearts with his love. That prior word pertains, not to the world mediated by meaning, but to the world of immediacy, to the unmediated experience of the mystery of love and awe.¹²

What is this prior, inner word? I would venture to say that it covers a twofold experience. First, an affective state that transcends our ordinary states: "being in love in an unrestricted fashion"—that is, "being in love without limits or qualifications or conditions or reservations."¹³ Second, a distinctive quality of consciousness, as indicated by the phrase "a *conscious* dynamic state of love, joy, peace."¹⁴ This particular quality consists in a fulfillment: "Being in love with God is the basic fulfilment of our conscious intentionality."¹⁵ As already mentioned, Lonergan situates such consciousness "on the fourth level of intentional consciousness": "It is this consciousness [on the fourth level] as brought to a fulfilment."¹⁶ The two sides of religious experience are concomitant: love and the consciousness that permeates it. In other words, the transcendent love is felt.

Even so, such consciousness differs from knowledge: "The dynamic state is conscious without being known."¹⁷ Lonergan offers a definition of faith: "Faith is the knowledge born of religious love." He distinguishes between two kinds of knowledge: "Besides the factual knowledge reached by experiencing, understanding, and verifying, there is another kind of knowledge reached through the discernment of value and the judgments of value of a person in love."¹⁸

Commenting on Pascal's famed phrase "the heart has reasons

11. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 112.

12. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*.

13. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 105 and 106, respectively.

14. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 106; italics are mine.

15. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 105.

16. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 106 and 107, respectively.

17. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 106.

18. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 115.

which reason does not know,” Lonergan construes “the heart’s reasons” as “feelings that are intentional responses to values,” in this case “an apprehension of transcendent value.”¹⁹ Unfortunately, in the response to transcendent value, he does not clearly distinguish between the feelings (the affective quality of consciousness) and the apprehension that we may have of them. Moreover, he does not spell out the components of that apprehension: the affective awareness that is felt, the meaning that is intuited without yet being formulated, and the two kinds of judgment (judgment of fact and judgment of value). His treatment of the intentional response, while creative, is too compact.²⁰

Lonergan seems to situate faith halfway between the inner and the outer word. Faith is more explicit than the inner word and less explicit than the outer word. It is located in a sequence that could be expounded as follows: a basic state of being in love unrestrictedly (prior word, also called inner word) → faith (the knowledge born of religious love) → the word as expressed (outer word) → belief (judgments of fact and of value) → decision → action.

Does the fact that faith is first and foremost an affective knowledge demote the outer word to a secondary place? Not for Lonergan, who declares, “One must not conclude that the outward word is something incidental. For it has a constitutive role.”²¹ He makes it clear that “the constitutive role of meaning” is far from being marginal: “Acts of meaning inform human living.”²² Talking about two persons in love, he explains, “It is the love that each freely and fully reveals to the other that brings about the radically new situation of being in love and that begins the unfolding of its life-long implications.”²³

19. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 115; see 30–31 for the notion of intentional response.

20. For a critique of Lonergan’s position on feeling and knowledge, see Terry J. Tekippe and Louis Roy, “Lonergan and the Fourth Level of Intentionality,” *American Catholic Philosophical Quarterly* 70 (1996): 225–42; see also Roy, *Transcendent Experiences*, 135–37 and 162–64.

21. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 112; on constitutive meaning, see 78.

22. Lonergan, “Theology in Its New Context,” in *A Second Collection*, ed. Robert M. Doran and John D. Dadoosky, vol. 13 of *Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2016), 54.

23. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 113.

And applying this interpersonal situation to love between God and us, he submits:

One needs the word—the word of tradition that has accumulated religious wisdom, the word of fellowship that unites those that share the gift of God’s love, the word of the gospel that announces that God has loved us first and, in the fulness of time, has revealed that love in Christ crucified, dead, and risen.²⁴

Lonerган reinforces his point of not separating the inner and the outer word: “God’s gift of his love has its proper counterpart in the revelation events in which God discloses to a particular people or to all mankind the completeness of his love for them.”²⁵ The outer word facilitates a focusing: “In the paschal mystery the love that is given inwardly is focused and inflamed, and that focusing unites Christians not only with Christ but also with one another.”²⁶

Earlier in *Method*, Lonergan introduces a category that helps to situate the role of Christ in the emergence of a person’s belief. Having quoted Newman’s motto *Cor ad cor loquitur* (“Heart speaks to heart”), he defines “incarnate meaning” as “the meaning of a person, of his way of life, of his words, or of his deeds.”²⁷ And a paper of his alludes to “the incarnate meaning to be contemplated in the life and ministry and, above all, in the suffering, death, and resurrection of Christ.”²⁸

Moreover, in a lecture delivered before *Method* was begun, he has recourse to the concept of mutual self-mediation to characterize a form of personal development that has two aspects; first, we mediate ourselves—that is, we actively constitute ourselves as human beings, especially in our religious dimension, thanks to the existential

24. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*.

25. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 283.

26. Lonergan, “Philosophy of God, and Theology: The Relationship between Philosophy of God and the Functional Specialty, Systematics,” in *Collected Works*, vol. 17, *Philosophical and Theological Papers 1965–1980*, ed. Robert C. Croken and Robert M. Doran (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2004), 170.

27. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 73.

28. Lonergan, “The Response of the Jesuit as Priest and Apostle in the Modern World,” in *A Second Collection*, 148.

decisions by which we make and transform ourselves; second, this process of growth unfolds with reference to Christ.

There is the mediation by our acts of what is immediate in us through the grace of God. Though the object of those acts is not exclusively Christ—it is everything—still, everything turns back to Christ in one way or another. That is, it is not merely a self-mediation in which we develop, but it is a self-mediation through another. One is becoming oneself, not just by experiences, insights, judgments, by choices, decisions, conversion, not just freely and deliberately, not just deeply and strongly, but as one who is carried along. One is doing so not in isolation, but in reference to Christ. The Father predestined us to be conformed to the image of his Son, through the merits of Christ, through the grace of Christ, through the example of Christ. Consequently, there is an element not merely of personal development, but of personal development in relation to another person.²⁹

In a way similar to Lonergan's, William Desmond contrasts "self-mediation," typical of Hegelian dialectic, and "self-mediation through another," which he calls "intermediation." Far from being self-centered, intermediation allows a person to meet the other in the middle—namely, in Plato's *metaxu*, interpreted by Eric Voegelin's as the "in-between."

The agapeic self is for the other. In this respect its self-transcendence is decentered. It is decentered because its center is outside of itself in the between; this is shapes, not just for itself, but to free the other to be itself as other.... So if the agapeic self gives itself over, it is not the "I will" of decisive self-assertion; it is the "I am willing" that is also willing to be nothing, even in the plenitude of its power and in the excess of its original energy. The "I am willing" is the "Here I am," now ready to be sacrifice for the other. "Sacrifice" literally means to make sacred. The agapeic self seeks to sanctify the willingness that gives itself up as an offering for the good of the other.³⁰

29. Lonergan, "The Mediation of Christ in Prayer," in *Collected Works*, vol. 6, *Philosophical and Theological Papers*, 180.

30. William Desmond, *Being and the Between* (Albany, N.Y.: SUNY Press, 1995), 409; see also xiv, 129, 178, and 408.

I think Lonergan would entirely concur with these lines by Desmond and would surely recognize here his own construal of Jesus and of all agapeic, self-sacrificing people as entirely committed to mutual self-mediation.

To wrap up this section, we can say that Lonergan situates religious conversion at the highest level of intentionality in its process of self-transcendence and that he nicely complements the inner word of infinite love with the role of the outer word and, for Christians, of the incarnate Word.

BELIEF

We can consider belief as an elaboration of the outer word. However, the importance of belief is far from being self-evident. So we must ask, how do people come to agree with religious beliefs? Lonergan answers, "Among the values that faith discerns is the value of believing the word of religion, of accepting the judgments of fact and the judgments of value that the religion proposes." The worth of belief derives from the fact that, far from being solitary, religious experience is shared and that "community invites expression."³¹ Furthermore, countless believers acknowledge this: "Not only the inner word that is God's gift of his love but also the outer word of the religious tradition comes from God."³²

Interestingly, in a previous section of *Method* on belief in general, Lonergan highlights the indispensable role of belief in daily life and observes that even scientists "do not suffer from a pointless mania to attain immanently generated knowledge of their fields."³³ "Immanently generated knowledge" refers to what individuals can verify for themselves—a very limited portion of science indeed.

Still, he maintains the primacy of faith over belief: "Beliefs do differ, but behind this difference there is a deeper unity. For beliefs

31. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 118.

32. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 119.

33. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 43; see also 41–47.

result from judgments of value, and the judgments of value relevant for religious belief come from faith, the eye of religious love, an eye that can discern God's self-disclosures."³⁴

What is absent here is the language of obligation, which we find in Aquinas and in Newman. In Aquinas's view, reported in chapter 3, believers see that some things are to be believed.³⁵ This "seeing" depends on the insight that Jesus Christ, the First Truth, must be believed. This is the formal aspect of faith. In a religious quest, at some point an individual comes to the conclusion that believing has now become a matter of obligation for her or him. As was noticed in chapter 4, Newman wrote to Mrs. William Froude, "Faith then is not a conclusion from premises, but the result of an act of the *will*, following upon a *conviction* that to believe is a *duty*."³⁶

Does Lonergan disagree with his mentors Thomas Aquinas and Newman in this respect? Evidently his phrasings are less compelling than theirs. Nevertheless, if "the eye of religious love . . . can discern God's self-disclosures," then the person makes judgments of fact and of value about those disclosures and must normally feel obliged to assent.³⁷ A few lines that precede on the same page in *Method* are clear about a divine revelation:

There is a personal entrance of God himself into history, a communication of God to his people, the advent of God's word into the world of religious expression. Such was the religion of Israel. Such has been Christianity.

Then not only the inner word that is God's gift of his love but also the outer word of the religious tradition comes from God.³⁸

He adds, "Finally, the word of religious expression is not just the objectification of the gift of God's love; in a privileged area it also is specific meaning, the word of God himself."³⁹

34. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 119.

35. *ST II-II*, q. 1, a. 4, ad 2 and ad 3; see also a. 5, ad 1.

36. Newman, *Letters and Diaries of John Henry Newman*, 12:228.

37. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 119; see the fuller quotation I gave, two paragraphs previously.

38. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*.

39. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*.

In fact, in chapter 2 of *Method*, in the section on beliefs, Lonergan uses the vocabulary of obligation. After the step in which a person judges that someone else's statement deserves to be believed, there comes the step in which the person reaches "the conclusion that the statement ought to be believed for, if believing is a good thing, then what can be believed should be believed."⁴⁰ Remarkably, the whole analysis of belief here is nonconfessional; it is applicable to any religious state or even to any purely moral situation.

If, in *Method*, Lonergan refrains from proposing the time-honored Roman Catholic view of faith as fashioned by Aquinas, it is, in my opinion, because his goal is not to expound a theology in conformity with a specific tradition. He himself declares, "I am writing not theology but method in theology. I am concerned not with the objects that theologians expound but with the operations that theologians perform."⁴¹ His project is ecumenical, in the broadest sense, which includes even non-Christian theologies. "By distinguishing faith and belief we have secured a basis both for ecumenical encounter and for an encounter between all religions with a basis in religious experience."⁴²

Toward the end of his chapter on religion, Lonergan writes, "In acknowledging a faith that grounds belief we are acknowledging what would have been termed the *lumen gratiae* or *lumen fidei* or infused wisdom."⁴³ He is right that such light of grace, light of faith, or infused wisdom amounts not to the outer word, but to the inner word—namely, to the subjective experience. The role of the outer word coming from the objective tradition is to explicate that religious experience and to situate it in a context of meaning. As he explains elsewhere, given that "meaning is the stuff of man's making of man," "a divine revelation is God's entry and his taking part in man's making of man. It is God's claim to have a say in the aims

40. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 46.

41. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, xii.

42. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 119; see 332–33.

43. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 123.

and purposes, the direction and development of human lives, human societies, human cultures, human history.”⁴⁴ Nevertheless, he prefers speaking of “word,” rather than of “revelation,” as a technical term, probably because the latter is commonly used metaphorically, whereas the former has a greater analogical potentiality (in the Thomist sense of analogy, in contradistinction to metaphor).

On this issue of the obligation to believe, Aquinas’s, Newman’s, and Lonergan’s considerations will be helpful to us in chapters 6 and 7.

A FIRST OBJECTION TO LONERGAN

Let us now scrutinize two criticisms leveled at Lonergan’s position on faith as deriving from religious love. The first comes from a Lutheran, partly neo-orthodox and partly Wittgensteinian theologian, whereas the second comes from a Roman Catholic, partly liberal and partly Lonerganian theologian.

In 1970, at the International Lonergan Congress, which took place in Florida, George Lindbeck gave a paper that was highly laudatory of Lonergan’s views on the development of dogma.⁴⁵ However, in a book that was published about fifteen years later, *The Nature of Doctrine*, he became critical of Lonergan’s method in theology as he denounced the adoption by liberal theologians of the concept of a generic human experience, which constituted a pseudo-common denominator among world religions. According to him, despite their best intentions, the liberals prefaced their theology with a notion of experience that preempted genuine revelation. We may think, for example, of Schleiermacher’s feeling of absolute dependence, Tillich’s ultimate concern, Wilfred Cantwell Smith’s faith, Rahner’s incomprehensible mystery, and Lonergan’s being-in-love in an unrestricted fashion.

44. Lonergan, “Theology in Its New Context,” 62.

45. George A. Lindbeck, “Protestant Problems with Lonergan on Development of Dogma,” in *Foundations of Theology: Papers from the International Lonergan Congress 1970*, ed. Philip McShane (Notre Dame, Ind.: University of Notre Dame Press, 1972), 115–23.

Lindbeck attributes an “experiential-expressive model” not only to Schleiermacher and his successors, but also to Rahner and Lonergan, although he adds that the latter two have attempted, unsuccessfully, to correct that model by combining it with the cognitive model represented by Aquinas.⁴⁶ The double-barreled adjective “experiential-expressive” designates the view that religious meaning would be encapsulated in a direct experience of ultimacy, subsequently to be echoed in “a doctrine of belief,” a *Glaubenslehre* in Schleiermacher’s sense, with no claim to absolute truth. In Lindbeck’s analysis, the mistake of both Rahner and Lonergan is to have tried to bring together two models that inevitably pull in opposed directions.

Presumably Lindbeck assumes that in Rahner and Lonergan the cross-cultural “transcendental” must be construed as logically derived from a rationalistic analysis of the human spirit and as a religious domain that stands by itself prior to any revelation and is independent of confessional belief. This would simply be a new version of the eighteenth-century “natural religion,” which usurped the right to judge what it disparagingly called “positive religion.” If we construe Rahner’s and Lonergan’s enterprise (in contradiction to their express aims) as driving a wedge between the transcendental and the categorial, or between faith and belief, and as unduly extolling the transcendental or faith, both described as unformulated knowledge, obviously we end up relativizing the content of Christian revelation. Consequently, the gospel would no longer be able to criticize any categorial expression in a particular culture, and no room would be left for evangelization.

Liberal theology’s concept of a generic religion ought to be distinguished from a universal openness to revelation, grounded in concrete minds and uncovered by a faith-inspired theology that values, as Aquinas and Newman did, the realm of reason, which has been

46. Lindbeck, *The Nature of Doctrine: Religion and Theology in a Postliberal Age* (Philadelphia: Westminster Press, 1984), 16–17, 31–32.

created by God and healed by grace (at least for those who have positively responded to grace). In contradistinction to Schleiermacher's somewhat perceptualist interpretation of the God-consciousness,⁴⁷ Lonergan proposes a better account of the interactions between reason, religious experience, and belief.⁴⁸ The manifold question of God operates alongside religious experience and thus functions as a universal openness to revelation.⁴⁹ While human intentionality orients the seekers toward transcendent meaning and truth, the basic state of being-in-love recognizes transcendent value.

However, to answer the question of God requires more than religious experience. Far from merely deriving from the inner word, the outward word of a religious institution adds something significant to the inner word that is spoken to the heart. Halfway between silence and thinking, faith, in Lonergan's sense, is the linchpin that triggers the transition from mystical immediacy to the intellectual articulations typical of a world mediated by meaning. The word of a tradition facilitates this transition to belief by exercising a role that is both cognitive, since it refers to reality, and constitutive of a community that shares experiences, understandings, judgments, and commitments.⁵⁰

Lindbeck wants to discount the inner word, construed as pseudo-private and unreal, since for him every human experience is mediated by language.⁵¹ Methodologically, therefore, he begins and ends with an unchanging belief system that regulates a community's worship and thinking. In Lindbeck's proposal, theology has to do solely with what Lonergan calls the "outer word"; actually, Lindbeck sees the outer word of tradition in a very different light. In *The Nature*

47. See Roy, "Schleiermacher's Epistemology," *Method: Journal of Lonergan Studies* 16 (1998): 25–46.

48. See Roy, *Engaging the Thought of Bernard Lonergan*, study 3, esp. the section entitled "An Integration of Faith and Reason."

49. See Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 101–3.

50. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 76–81 and 298–99.

51. This intricate issue is discussed in Roy, *Transcendent Experiences*, 137–39, 175–81.

of *Doctrine* the sources of Christian belief and the factors involved in its development (in interaction with innumerable non-Christian forms of thought) remain epistemologically unaccounted for.⁵² Believers must obey linguistic rules, which shape their apprehension of religious realities. Any particular tradition is equated with a fixed datum, which cannot be rationally compared with the data of other religious traditions, since their respective rules make them incommensurable.

As Neil Ormerod perceptively notes, Lindbeck's vision is based on "static conceptualist assumptions" and on a disregard of the dynamism of "questions, problems and answers." The consequence is that "his [Lindbeck's] conceptualist assumptions have trapped the subject within the horizon created by that tradition [his religious tradition]."⁵³ And as Charles Hefling rightly states, Lindbeck overlooks Lonergan's recurrent insistence on the way we arrive at correct judgments.⁵⁴

By stressing the inner word, does Lonergan condone the anthropocentrism of Schleiermacher, of liberal Protestantism, or of Catholic modernism?⁵⁵ The answer to this question must take into consideration his methodological purpose. Accordingly, he underlines the fact that his view of beliefs is open both to those currents and to conservative versions of Christianity.

52. According to Michael H. McCarthy, *The Crisis of Philosophy* (Albany, N.Y.: SUNY Press, 1990), Wittgenstein (who has deeply influenced Lindbeck) does not explain how mathematicians adopt "variable rules of procedure" not merely "on pragmatic grounds" (136); indeed, "the demand that we justify our linguistic practice is said to be superfluous" (138). In "The Critique of Realism," *Method: Journal of Lonergan Studies* 10 (1992): 107–14, McCarthy calls attention to the same lacuna in the larger context of any community of language users.

53. Neil Ormerod, *Method, Meaning and Revelation: The Meaning and Function of Revelation in Bernard Lonergan's "Method in Theology"* (Lanham, Md.: University Press of America, 2000), 156 and 203; see also 29–32 and 192–204. See my laudatory review of that book in *New Blackfriars* 82 (2001): 597–98.

54. See Charles C. Hefling Jr., "Turning Liberalism Inside-Out," *Method: Journal of Lonergan Studies* 3 (1985): 68.

55. I address this issue more at length in *Engaging the Thought of Bernard Lonergan*, study 5.

My account of religious beliefs does not imply that they are more than objectifications of religious experience. It is a view quite acceptable to the nineteenth-century liberal Protestant or to the twentieth-century Catholic modernist. But it is unacceptable to most of the traditional forms of Christianity, in which religious beliefs are believed to have their origin in charism, prophecy, inspiration, revelation, the word of God, the life, death, and resurrection of Christ. Obviously, to be applicable to this traditional type of religious belief, the skeleton model needs to be fleshed out, and fleshing it out calls for creativity.⁵⁶

Lonerган maintains that he methodologically offers a model—which he also calls a construct or an ideal type—that must be completed by theological data and reflections, either in the direction of liberal or modernist standpoints or in the direction of long-established standpoints. Consequently, he concludes, “In that case religious beliefs would be objectifications not only of internal experience but also of the externally uttered word of God.”⁵⁷

However, he gives the impression of coming dangerously close to liberalism and modernism when he approves of Rahner for having written that “in theology theocentrism and anthropocentrism coincide. On this basis, he [Rahner] desires all theological statements to be matched by statements of their meaning in human terms.” Nonetheless, Lonergan warns us against a false version: “Explicitly Father Rahner excludes a modernist interpretation of his view, namely, that theological doctrines are to be taken as statements about merely human reality.”⁵⁸ Thanks to his critical realism, Lonergan’s method decisively precludes any immanentism or subjectivism.⁵⁹

56. Lonergan, “Faith and Beliefs,” in *Philosophical and Theological Papers 1965–1980*, 46–47.

57. *Ibid.*, 47.

58. Lonergan, “Theology and Man’s Future,” in *A Second Collection*, 148; see “The Future of Christianity,” in *A Second Collection*, 161; also Karl Rahner, “Theology and Anthropology,” trans. Graham Harrison, in *Theological Investigations* (New York: Herder, 1972) 9:28–45.

59. Much more successfully than Rahner; see Roy, *Engaging the Thought of Bernard Lonergan*, study 8. My strictures on Rahner in that study must be assessed in reference to my positive treatment of other aspects of his thought, in *Transcendent Experiences*, chap. 8.

Still, taking into account the justified criticisms leveled against the anthropocentrism that characterizes liberal Protestantism and Catholic modernism, I would suggest that in accord with chapter 1, in the section entitled, "Reading the Human Condition Theologically," we refrain to speak of Lonergan's method as an "anthropocentrism," and we rather call it "an anthropological method" (in the transcendental sense that he adopts), which is not a precipitate of some idealism, but an implementation of his critical realism.

I must reiterate that Lonergan sees no competition between the inner and the outer word. On the contrary, they reinforce each other. The inner word allows us to discern the beauty and luminosity of the outer word; the outer word encourages us to take to heart the effects of the inner word in us.

Consequently, on the one hand, he never belittles the validity of religious beliefs in the way Schleiermacher and liberal theologians do. Of course, it is not that, for them, all beliefs are unimportant: some are pronounced helpful. Still, in their eyes, beliefs are not considered to be normative in the sense that they would possess a permanent validity.

On the other hand, in *Method* he does not argue for specific beliefs. This decision of his belongs to his theological methodology. Consequently, as a methodologist, he brings in the role of Christ merely as a brief illustration. However, we have no indications that later in his life he abandoned his robust dogmatic stance in Catholic theology itself.⁶⁰ Having situated it in the dynamic context of the multiple developments of doctrines, he had no need to forego his dogmatic stance, as will be made manifest in the text to follow.

In this section, I have endeavored to fairly represent Lindbeck's view of theology and have contrasted it with Lonergan's. With the help of Ormerod and Hefling, connoisseurs who addressed Lindbeck's

60. An instance of that dogmatic stance is Lonergan's treatment of the Council of Chalcedon, in a lecture given in 1975 and entitled "Christology Today: Methodological Reflections," in *A Third Collection*, 74–99.

critique of Lonergan, I have replied to Lindbeck that a subjective approach to faith does not end up being subjectivist and does not necessarily set conditions that Christian revelation must obey, as if placing it in a procrustean bed. Instead, Lonergan's painstaking justification of the human person's universal intentionality provides a cross-cultural epistemology that can be put at the service of the divine outer word.

A SECOND OBJECTION TO LONERGAN

The second criticism that will be tackled has been voiced by David Tracy, interestingly at the same Lonergan congress in Florida, in which Lindbeck participated.⁶¹ By and large, Tracy remains intellectually close to Lonergan, who was his mentor at the Gregorian University in Rome, so he upholds Lonergan's grounding of *intellectual* conversion.⁶² What he questions is Lonergan's grounding of *religious* conversion, which appears to be merely dogmatic, whereas, according to Tracy, it ought to be critical. In reference to a couple of Lonergan's writings prior to *Method in Theology*, he is wary about a past attempt, on the part of Lonergan, to found his theological views "in the authoritative claims of the Roman Catholic tradition," although he opines that Lonergan, after having clarified his method, would no longer go this way.⁶³ Tracy is afraid that, as described by Lonergan, the functional specialty called "foundations" does not provide the required critical justification of theological discourse.

Given that the validity of Lonergan's theological method depends, to a large extent, on religious conversion, Tracy asks, don't we need "critical grounds for the enterprise itself—more precisely,

61. David Tracy, "Lonergan's Foundational Theology: An Interpretation and a Critique," in *Foundations of Theology: Papers from the International Lonergan Congress 1970*, ed. Philip McShane (Notre Dame, Ind.: University of Notre Dame Press, 1972), 197–222, esp. 214–22.

62. Tracy, "Lonergan's Foundational Theology," 215; see also Tracy's first book, *The Achievement of Bernard Lonergan*, with a foreword by Bernard Lonergan (New York: Herder and Herder, 1970).

63. Tracy, "Lonergan's Foundational Theology," 215; see also 255n12.

for the truth-value of the claims to ultimacy of religious and explicitly theological language?" Otherwise put, the question is, "What, then, are the conditions for the possibility of religious and explicitly theological meanings?"⁶⁴ As instances of "two presuppositions of a Christian foundational theology" that would need to be defended, Tracy mentions "the theistic thematisation of religious experience" and "the Christological claim to uniqueness as the thematisation of Christian religious experience."⁶⁵

In his response, Lonergan agrees with Tracy that the specialty called "foundations" cannot be dogmatically established, since it cannot be built on dogmas. In a methodical theology, the dogmas will emerge later—namely, in the functional specialty called "doctrines." Nevertheless, Lonergan contends that foundations can be grounded in the believers' authentic subjectivity. To do so, theologians are helped by the first four functional specialties—research, interpretation, history, and dialectic—while the fifth specialty, foundations, explicates the threefold conversion.

Fittingly, then, we notice an objective and a subjective aspect to this theological grounding: "The method would ground foundations, objectively, in the situation revealed by dialectic and, on the side of subjective development, in intellectual, moral, and religious conversion."⁶⁶ Earlier in his response, Lonergan insists that "the [most basic] theological principle is religious conversion itself. It is not knowledge of religious conversion, awareness of religious conversion, interpretation of the psychological phenomena of conversion, propositions concerning conversion. It is simply the reality of the transformation named conversion."⁶⁷ Needless to say, such conversion should not be seen as an individualistic achievement, but shared by a community of scholars in dialogue both with

64. Tracy, "Lonergan's Foundational Theology," 214 and 216–17.

65. Tracy, "Lonergan's Foundational Theology," 255, endnote 14; see 256, endnote 27.

66. "Bernard Lonergan Responds," in *Foundations of Theology*, 231; see also 230.

67. "Bernard Lonergan Responds," 227.

past thinkers and among themselves. Hence, in Lonergan's eyes, the objective-subjective character of the theological enterprise.⁶⁸

This "reality of the transformation named conversion" is a datum that may be registered and affirmed. In *Insight*, in the context of intellectual conversion, Lonergan declares, as he retraces his steps:

Self-affirmation has been considered as a concrete judgment of fact. The contradiction of self-negation has been indicated. Behind that contradiction there have been discerned natural inevitabilities and spontaneities that constitute the possibility of knowing, not by demonstrating that one can know, but pragmatically by engaging one in the process. Nor in the last resort can one reach a deeper foundation than that pragmatic engagement.⁶⁹

This project of establishing an *intellectual* foundation, which we find in *Insight*, recurs in a parallel and yet different manner when an *affective* foundation has to be established, at the time Lonergan was writing *Method in Theology*. There is no univocity but an analogy between uncovering an intellectual foundation (on the second and third levels of intentionality) and uncovering an affective foundation (on the fourth level), as Frederick Crowe observes in his brief remarks on the Tracy-Lonergan exchange in Florida.⁷⁰ Thus, in Lonergan's response of 1970, according to a viewpoint broader than *Insight's*—a viewpoint that includes the moral and religious conversions as well as the intellectual—the knower's self-affirmation of *Insight* becomes *the entire person's* most fundamental option: "Foundations, then, consists in a decision that selects one horizon and rejects others."⁷¹

In an interview granted at the same congress, Lonergan reiterated his view:

68. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 235–44, 251–53, 262–66, and 292–93.

69. Lonergan, *Collected Works*, vol. 3, *Insight*, 356.

70. Frederick E. Crowe, "An Exploration of Lonergan's New Notion of Value," in *Appropriating the Lonergan Idea*, ed. Michael Vertin (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2006), 66–67.

71. "Bernard Lonergan Responds," 230.

Being in love is a fact, and it's what you are, it's existential. And your living flows from it. It's the first principle, as long as it lasts. . . . And critically grounding knowledge isn't finding the ground for knowledge. It's already there. Being critical means eliminating the ordinary nonsense, the systematically misleading images and so on; the mythical account.

To the question "might one not then be deceived?" he answers:

One can be deceiving himself. If one is deceiving oneself one is not in love. One is mistaking something for love. Love is something that proves itself. "By their fruits you shall know them," and "in fear and trembling work out your salvation" and all the rest of it. Love isn't cocksure, either.⁷²

Perhaps spurred by that earlier discussion with Tracy, Lonergan writes, in *Method*, "Only God can give that gift [of his love], and the gift itself is self-justifying. People in love have not reasoned themselves into being in love."⁷³ About such being-in-love, he claims, "One has only to experience it in oneself or witness it in others, to find in it its own justification."⁷⁴ He explains:

In the realm of religious experience Olivier Rabut has asked whether there exists any unassailable fact. He found such a fact in the existence of love. It is as though a room were filled with music though one can have no sure knowledge of its source. There is in the world, as it were, a charged field of love and meaning; here and there it reaches a notable intensity; but it is ever unobtrusive, hidden, inviting each of us to join. And join we must if we are to perceive it, for our perceiving is through our own loving.⁷⁵

Still, the exercise of this "unassailable fact" may be blocked by various types of bias:

Accordingly, while there is no need to justify critically the charity described by St. Paul in the thirteenth chapter of his first epistle to the Corinthians, there is always a great need to eye very critically any religious individual or

72. "An Interview with Fr. Bernard Lonergan, SJ," in Lonergan, *A Second Collection*, 229 and 230.

73. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 123.

74. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 283–84.

75. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 290. Lonergan is paraphrasing Olivier Rabut, *L'expérience religieuse fondamentale* (Tournai: Casterman, 1969), 168.

group and to discern beyond the real charity they may well have been granted the various types of bias that may distort or block their exercise of it.⁷⁶

A last excerpt deserves to be quoted, drawn from another interview accorded by Lonergan: "Necessary truths arise from the transformation of the subject—who is not necessary. Grace is given: it has to be fully accepted and lived. There is no intellectual foundation other than faith."⁷⁷ It must be recalled that for him, faith is "the knowledge born of religious love."⁷⁸ Notwithstanding the presence of such love and knowledge derived from it, there ever remains an uncertainty regarding our being in love. St. Thomas defends the thesis that one can never know, in an apodictic manner, whether one is or is not in a state of grace. But he also holds that one may detect several signs that show the high probability of being in that state.⁷⁹ Such uncertainty is compatible with faith certainty, which our studies of the biblical faith, of Thomas, and of Newman have clarified.

Diverging from a foundationalist search for a logically unassailable point of departure, both *Insight* and *Method* begin not from presumably self-evident premises taken either from the Bible, as in the old Protestant apologetic, or from the magisterium, as in the old Roman Catholic apologetic,⁸⁰ but with the intentional, conscious reality of the (at least half-converted) human subject who thinks, acts, and loves. Thus Lonergan does with religious data what scientists do with sense data: they do not try to ground the data, but they recognize that such data just happen to be present, that such data nonetheless provide indispensable information, and that science consists of observing and analysing them in order to come to judgments of fact.

76. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 284; notice the quotation from Olivier Rabut, 290.

77. Quoted by Pierre Robert, "Theology and Spiritual Life: Encounter with Bernard Lonergan," in *Lonergan Workshop*, ed. Fred Lawrence (Boston: Boston College, 1994), 10:342.

78. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 115.

79. Aquinas, *ST I-II*, q. 112, a. 5; *The Disputed Questions on Truth*, q. 10, a. 10; *Super Secundam Epistolam ad Corinthios Lectura*, Caput 12, Lectio 1, no. 445, in *Super Epistolas S. Pauli Lectura*.

80. See Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 270.

More than a century before Lonergan came to grips with this issue, Newman had adopted the same solution as he commented on two passages written by St. Paul:

And, it may be, this is something of the Apostle's meaning, when he speaks of the witness of the Spirit. Perhaps he is speaking of that satisfaction and rest which the soul experiences in proportion as it is able to surrender itself wholly to God, and to have no desire, no aim, but to please Him. When we are awake, we are conscious we are awake, in a sense in which we cannot fancy we are, when we are asleep. When we have discovered the solution of some difficult problem in science, we have a conviction about it which is distinct from that which accompanies fancied discoveries or guesses. When we realize a truth we have a feeling which they have not, who take words for things. And so, in like manner, if we are allowed to find that real and most sacred object on which our heart may fix itself, a fulness of peace will follow, which nothing but it can give. In proportion as we have given up the love of the world, and are dead to the creature, and, on the other hand, are born of the Spirit unto love of our Maker and Lord, this love carries with it its own evidence whence it comes. Hence the Apostle says, "The Spirit itself beareth witness with our spirit, that we are the children of God" (Rom 8:16). Again, he speaks of Him "who hath sealed us, and given the earnest of the Spirit in our hearts" (2 Cor 1:22).⁸¹

This section has discussed Tracy's interesting objection to Lonergan's view of religious experience. Tracy is concerned with grounding theological method and discourse. In his reply, Lonergan asserts that religious experience cannot be *critically*—that is, epistemologically—grounded. Instead, it is simply as a matter of fact *present* in the religious experience of the theologian—an experience shared with other scholars in dialogue, both with past thinkers and among themselves. The task of the specialty called "foundations" consists in explicating a "being-in-love" that is in itself conscious without yet being known.

81. Newman, "The Thought of God," sermon 22, in part V, in *Parochial and Plain Sermons*, 1152.

INTELLECTUAL CONVERSION AND
CRITICAL REALISM

Intellectual conversion consists in the kind of self-knowledge whereby an individual affirms oneself as a knower. Lonergan calls such self-knowledge, as explicated, "cognitional theory."

Here is how he represents cognitional theory. Attentiveness to one's cognitive operations allows philosophers to notice the way those operations occur and interact. In intelligent minds, whether in practical matters or in any science, a series of operations spontaneously take place, along four basic steps, the first of which is perceptual experience, and the other three consisting of three types of questioning. Thus, sense data, once perceived, naturally become, in one's memory and imagination, images (in the broadest sense) about which one spontaneously asks, what is this? How has it happened? Why does it work this way? Insights are answers to this type of question. Yet insights remain hypotheses, and therefore the inquirer asks a second type of question: Is it so? Is it the case? Is reality as I have understood it? In response, one verifies, tests, weighs the evidence, one realizes that one has fulfilled the conditions for one's knowing that the hypothesis is true, and one makes judgments of fact about it. Finally, as a doer and not only as a knower, one asks a third type of question: How can I act in the present situation? Is it worthwhile to do this or that? What should I decide? This latter kind of question eventually results in judgments of value and in decisions.⁸²

Lonergan's cognitional theory purports to be universal, and rightly so. As he notes in *Method*, any attempt to demolish it is self-defeating, since in order to do so, one cannot but perform the very acts one attempts to deny.⁸³ In any religious study, philosophy of religion, or theology, the process of formulation has no option but to implement the natural laws of the human mind. Admittedly,

82. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, chap. 1, section 2, and chap. 2, sections 3–4.

83. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 19; see also Roy, *Mystical Consciousness*, 18.

we should not expect to achieve all the exact solutions at the beginning of an inquiry. Yet, both in principle and in practice, whenever people have the humility to recognize their shortcomings and biases, a self- and group-correcting process of scholarly learning spontaneously unfolds.

In its turn, cognitional theory generates right conceptions about the human person (philosophical anthropology), about intentionality, relatedness to the real, objectivity (epistemology), and about the several facets of being (metaphysics). Grounded in the self-knowledge that makes an adequate cognitional theory possible, Lonergan's fundamental position is a critical realism.

Intellectual conversion is a radical clarification and, consequently, the elimination of an exceedingly stubborn and misleading myth concerning reality, objectivity, and human knowledge. The myth is that knowing is like looking, that objectivity is seeing what is there to be seen and not seeing what is not there, and the real is what is out there now to be looked at. . . . Knowing, accordingly, is not just seeing; it is experiencing, understanding, judging, and believing. The criteria of objectivity are not just the criteria of ocular vision; they are the compounded criteria of experiencing, of understanding, of judging, and of believing. The reality known is not just looked at; it is given in experience, organized and extrapolated by understanding, posited by judgment and belief.⁸⁴

Finally, we must detect the influence of religious conversion upon intellectual conversion (by way of moral conversion), which is neatly summed up in *Method* as follows:

From a causal viewpoint, one would say that first there is God's gift of his love. Next, the eye of this love reveals values in their splendor, while the strength of this love brings about their realization, and that is moral conversion. Finally, among the values discerned by the eye of love is the value of believing the truths taught by the religious tradition, and in such tradition and belief are the seeds of intellectual conversion. For the word, spoken and heard, proceeds from and penetrates to all four levels of intentional consciousness. Its content is not just a content of experience but a content

84. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 238.

of experience and understanding and judging and deciding. The analogy of sight yields the cognitional myth. But fidelity to the word engages the whole man.⁸⁵

Lonerган highlights the fact that most of the time religious conversion comes chronologically first. We have seen that “being-in-love” in an unrestricted fashion generates faith as “the knowledge born of religious love.” This faith spontaneously moves in the direction of moral conversion and of intellectual conversion, since these two kinds of conversion carry within themselves a desire to know truth and reality more adequately. However, Lonergan would not deny that moral and intellectual conversion also play a significant role in sustaining religious conversion that, after its inception, needs to be reinforced by right decisions and correct ideas about Christian commitments.

CONCLUDING REMARKS

As the preceding quotation states, religious conversion, which is principally affective, puts people in touch with great values and stirs up the desire to implement them (moral conversion). Among those values is the importance of belief, which is enhanced by attuning to the beauty and profundity of traditional writings, such as the Bible and the liturgy. Intellectual conversion consists in acquiring a kind of self-knowledge that is correctly expressed in cognitional theory, that yields an exact epistemology, and that unfolds into an accurate metaphysics. It is this intellectual conversion, prompted by religious conversion, that founds critical realism—namely, the reasoned hope that human beings can reach the real in a critical manner through the exercise of considered judgments.

Openness to divine revelation then depends on a quest for meaning and truth and on an affective experience. Authentic reception of revelation is considerably assisted by the fine balance, which Lonergan provides, between the affective and the intellectual aspects of

85. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 243.

human intentionality, between the inner and the outer word, and between experiential knowledge and tradition.

If we compare Lonergan with the two great thinkers he considered his mentors—namely, Thomas Aquinas and Newman—we can say that, having borrowed much from them, he has added the following contribution: situating religious experience in the broad context of human intentionality and of metaphysics, while employing the categories of interiority. So the language of psychology, which was not absent in Aquinas and Newman, is used by Lonergan in a manner that readily adjusts itself to the perspectives of Western audiences.

